

# Multirole combat aircraft

A **multirole combat aircraft** is a combat aircraft intended to perform different roles in combat. Aircraft such as the F-35 Lightning II can be called a 'multirole fighter'<sup>[1]</sup> These roles can include air to air combat, air support, aerial bombing, reconnaissance, electronic warfare, and suppression of air defenses.

## Definition

A multi-role fighter aircraft is a type of military jet that is designed to perform a variety of combat missions rather than being specialized for a single role. These aircraft combine the capabilities of air-to-air fighters and air-to-ground attack aircraft, offering versatility and efficiency on the battlefield.

More roles can be added, such as aerial reconnaissance, forward air control, and electronic-warfare aircraft. Attack missions include the subtypes air interdiction, suppression of enemy air defense (SEAD), and close air support (CAS).

## Multirole vs air-superiority

Multirole has also been applied to one aircraft with both major roles, a primary air-to-air combat role, and a secondary role like air-to-surface attack. However, those designed with an emphasis on aerial combat are usually regarded as air superiority fighters and usually deployed solely in that role, even though they are theoretically capable of ground attack. The Eurofighter Typhoon and Dassault Rafale are classified as multirole fighters; however the Typhoon is frequently considered an air superiority fighter due to its higher dogfighting prowess while its built-in strike capability has a lighter bomb load compared to contemporaries like the Rafale, which sacrifices air-to-air ability for a heavier payload.<sup>[2]</sup>

For the US Navy, the F-14 Tomcat was initially deployed solely as an air-superiority fighter, as well as fleet defense interceptor and tactical aerial reconnaissance. By contrast, the multirole F/A-18 Hornet was designed as strike fighter while having only enough of an edge to defend itself against enemy fighters if needed. While the F-14 had an undeveloped secondary ground attack capability (with a Stores



United States Air Force F-35A Lightning IIs, fifth-generation multirole stealth fighters



The de Havilland Mosquito was a Night fighter which performed light bombing and reconnaissance during World War II.

Management System (SMS) that included air-to-ground options as well as rudimentary software in the AWG-9), the Navy did not want to risk it in the air-to-ground role at the time, due to its lack of proper defensive electronic countermeasures (DECM) and radar homing and warning (RHAW) for overland operations, as well as the fighter's high cost. In the 1990s, the US Navy added LANTIRN pods to its F-14s and deployed them on precision ground-attack missions.<sup>[3]</sup>

## Swing-role

Some aircraft, like the Saab JAS 39 Gripen,<sup>[4]</sup> are called *swing-role*, to emphasize the ability of a quick role change, either at short notice, or even within the same mission. According to the Military Dictionary: "the ability to employ a multi-role aircraft for multiple purposes during the same mission."<sup>[5]</sup>

According to BAE Systems, "an aircraft that can accomplish both air-to-air and air-to-surface roles on the same mission and swing between these roles instantly offers true flexibility. This reduces cost, increases effectiveness and enhances interoperability with allied air forces".<sup>[6]</sup>

"[Swing-role] capability also offers considerable cost-of-ownership benefits to operational commanders."<sup>[7]</sup>

## History

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Although the term "multirole aircraft" may be relatively novel, certain airframes in history have proven versatile to multiple roles. In particular, the Junkers Ju 88 was renowned in Germany for being a "jack-of-all-trades", capable of performing as a bomber, dive bomber, night fighter, and so on, much as the British de Havilland Mosquito did as a fast bomber/strike aircraft, reconnaissance, and night fighter. The Hawker Hart was also quite 'multirole' in its numerous variants, being designed as a light bomber but serving as an army cooperation aircraft, a two-seat fighter, a fleet spotter, a fighter-bomber (in fact it was one of the most successful)<sup>[8]</sup> and a trainer.



An RAF Panavia Tornado GR4 flying through Mach Loop

The US joint forces F-4 Phantom II built by McDonnell-Douglas also fits the definition of a multi-role aircraft in its various configurations of the basic airframe design. The various F-4 Phantom II configurations were used in air-to-air, fighter bomber, reconnaissance, and suppression of enemy air defenses (SEAD) mission roles to name a few.<sup>[9]</sup>

The first use of the term was by the multinational European project named **Multi-Role Combat Aircraft**, which was formed in 1968 to produce an aircraft capable of tactical strike, aerial reconnaissance, air defense, and maritime roles. The design was aimed to replace a multitude of different types in the cooperating air forces. The project produced the Panavia Tornado, which used the same basic design to undertake a variety of roles, the Tornado IDS (Interdictor/Strike) variant and later the Panavia Tornado ADV (Air Defence Variant).<sup>[10][11]</sup> By contrast, the F-15 Eagle which was another fighter aircraft of that era was designed for air superiority and interception,<sup>[12]</sup> with the mantra "not a pound for air to

ground",<sup>[13]</sup> although the F-15C did have a rarely used secondary ground attack capability. That program eventually evolved into the F-15E Strike Eagle interdictor/strike derivative which retained the air-to-air combat lethality of earlier F-15s.<sup>[14]</sup>

The newest fighter jet that fits the definition of 'multi-role' is the Lockheed Martin F-35 Lightning II/Joint Strike Fighter, designed to perform stealth-based ground/naval strike, fighter, reconnaissance and electronic warfare roles. Like a modern-day F-4, 3 variants of this aircraft fulfill the various strike and air defense roles among its joint service requirements: the standard variant is intended to eventually replace the F-16 and A-10 in the USAF and other Western air forces, a STOVL version intended to replace the Harrier in US Marine Corps, British Royal Air Force and Royal Navy service, and a carrier variant intended to eventually replace the older F/A-18C/D for the US Navy and other F/A-18 operators. The F-35's design goal can be compared to its larger and more air superiority-focused cousin, the F-22 Raptor.

## Aircraft

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Below is a list of some current examples.



A US Navy F/A-18F Super Hornet

| Country/territory                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   | Manufacturer                                                                                                      | Aircraft                          | Introduced <sup>[N 1]</sup> |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------|-----------------------------|
|  <u>United States</u>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              | <u>Lockheed Martin</u>                                                                                            | <u>F-16</u>                       | 1978 <sup>[15]</sup>        |
|  <u>Soviet Union</u>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               | <u>MAPO (OKB-155)</u>                                                                                             | <u>MiG-29</u>                     | 1982 <sup>[16]</sup>        |
|  <u>United States</u>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              | <u>Boeing</u>                                                                                                     | <u>F-15E</u>                      | 1988 <sup>[14]</sup>        |
|  <u>Taiwan</u>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     | <u>AIDC</u>                                                                                                       | <u>F-CK-1</u>                     | 1992                        |
|  <u>Russia</u>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     | <u>KnAAPO / Irkut Corporation (Sukhoi)</u>                                                                        | <u>Su-30</u>                      | 1996                        |
|  <u>Sweden</u>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     | <u>Saab</u>                                                                                                       | <u>JAS 39</u>                     | 1997                        |
|  <u>United States</u>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              | <u>Boeing</u>                                                                                                     | <u>F/A-18E/F</u>                  | 1999 <sup>[17]</sup>        |
|  <u>Japan</u>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      | <u>Mitsubishi</u>                                                                                                 | <u>Mitsubishi F-2</u>             | 2000                        |
|  <u>France</u>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     | <u>Dassault</u>                                                                                                   | <u>Rafale</u>                     | 2001                        |
|  <u>Germany</u><br> <u>Italy</u><br> <u>Spain</u><br> <u>UK</u> | <u>Eurofighter</u>                                                                                                | <u>Typhoon</u>                    | 2003                        |
|  <u>China</u>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      | <u>Chengdu Aerospace</u>                                                                                          | <u>J-10</u>                       | 2005                        |
|  <u>Pakistan</u><br> <u>China</u>                                                                                                                                                                                                | <u>CAC / PAC</u>                                                                                                  | <u>JF-17</u>                      | 2007                        |
|  <u>Russia</u>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   | <u>Mikoyan</u>                                                                                                    | <u>Mikoyan MiG-29K</u>            | 2010                        |
|  <u>China</u>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    | <u>Chengdu</u>                                                                                                    | <u>J-20</u>                       | 2011                        |
|  <u>China</u>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    | <u>Shenyang</u>                                                                                                   | <u>J-16</u>                       | 2012                        |
|  <u>China</u>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    | <u>Shenyang</u>                                                                                                   | <u>J-15</u>                       | 2013                        |
|  <u>Russia</u>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   | <u>UAC (Sukhoi)</u>                                                                                               | <u>Su-35</u>                      | 2014                        |
|  <u>Russia</u>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   | <u>NAPO (Sukhoi)</u>                                                                                              | <u>Su-34</u>                      | 2014                        |
|  <u>United States</u>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            | <u>Lockheed Martin</u>                                                                                            | <u>F-35 Lightning II</u>          | 2015 <sup>[18]</sup>        |
|  <u>India</u>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    | <u>HAL</u>                                                                                                        | <u>HAL Tejas</u>                  | 2015                        |
|  <u>Russia</u>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   | <u>United Aircraft Corporation (Mikoyan)</u>                                                                      | <u>Mikoyan MiG-35</u>             | 2019                        |
|  <u>Russia</u>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   | <u>UAC (by KnAAPO, Sukhoi)</u>                                                                                    | <u>Su-57</u>                      | 2020                        |
|  <u>South Korea</u><br> <u>Indonesia</u>                                                                                                                                                                                      | <u>Korea Aerospace Industries / Indonesian Aerospace</u>                                                          | <u>KAI KF-21 Boramae</u>          | 2026 <sup>[19]</sup>        |
|  <u>Turkey</u>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   | <u>Turkish Aerospace Industries<sup>[20]</sup></u>                                                                | <u>TAI TF Kaan<sup>[21]</sup></u> | 2030s <sup>[22]</sup>       |
|  <u>Indonesia</u>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                | <u>PT. Infoglobal Teknologi Semesta (<a href="https://www.infoglobal.co.id">https://www.infoglobal.co.id</a>)</u> | <u>Infoglobal I-22 Sikatan</u>    | <u>[23]</u>                 |

## See also

- Air superiority fighter
- Attack aircraft

- Fighter-bomber
- Interceptor aircraft
- Interdictor
- Lead-in fighter trainer
- Light combat aircraft
- Strike fighter
- Tactical bomber

## Notes

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1. The date the aircraft was first introduced into service

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